



YAMIL LAGE AFP/Getty Images

A U.S. flag adorns a pedicab in Havana. Many wonder if talks with Washington mean the end of revolution.

Trump turns his eye to Cuban leaders

Energy blockade may wring concessions from Havana. Regime change will be harder.

By **PATRICK J. McDONNELL,**
ANA CEBALLOS
AND **KATE LINTHICUM**

MEXICO CITY — For more than six decades, communist Cuba thwarted every destabilizing measure Washington aimed its way — assassination plots, a trade embargo, sabotage, travel bans, and, most notoriously, the Bay of Pigs invasion in 1961, when Fidel Castro's revolution was still young and the Cold War raging.

Now, many are wondering: Is the death knell finally tolling for the Cuban Revolution?

And is President Trump on track to achieve a goal — toppling the island's communist rulers — that eluded John F. Kennedy and successive presidents?

Trump has stated repeatedly that Cuba is next in his crosshairs, after his ongoing war against Iran and the overthrow in January of Venezuelan President Nicolás Maduro.

But many experts caution that predictions of communist rule ending have proved illusory.

"A lot of people have lost their shirts betting on the end of these guys over the last 67 years, so I wouldn't go that far," said Jorge Castañeda, Mexico's former foreign minister. "But the only way [Cuba's government] can save itself is by doing everything on the economic front that Trump and the Miami people want them to do, in exchange for holding on to political power."

It was oil — specifically, Trump's de facto energy blockade — that finally forced Havana's entrenched leadership to go to the negotiating table with its long-time nemesis across the Florida Straits.

On Friday, Cuban President Miguel Díaz-Canel went on national television and confirmed that Havana has been engaged in secret talks with the Trump administration.

Underscoring the gravity of the moment, Díaz-Canel stressed that the talks were directed by him and "the historic leader of our revolution," Raúl Castro, the nonagenarian younger brother of Fidel, who died in 2016.

Díaz-Canel's words masked what was, for adherents of a revolution celebrated by the global left, a painful reality.

"Cuba isn't negotiating out of conviction, but out of [See Cuba, A3]

San Francisco offers a vision for a downtown L.A. reboot

Subsidized pop-ups boost bay city's foot traffic and retail areas

By **Roger Vincent**



ETIENNE LAURENT For The Times

FIRMS have left downtown for more vibrant L.A. areas. Above, a boarded-up building on Broadway.

As much of downtown Los Angeles continues to feel dark and deserted, local businesses want the city to steal San Francisco's secret for firing up foot traffic.

The tech mecca has slowly begun to emerge from one of the country's deepest declines in downtown retail, in part through a program that peppered the city with subsidized pop-up shops.

The Vacant to Vibrant program turned abandoned spaces into bakeries, bookstores, cafes, chocolateries, galleries and other things.

Local entrepreneurs were given grants and support from the city and charities, as well as months of free rent to set up shop. The idea is to leverage empty storefronts to build buzz and entice more shoppers to city sidewalks.

Although San Francisco [See Downtown, A9]

Amid probe, Newsom aide exited with a \$50,000 vacation payout

By **Melody Gutierrez**

SACRAMENTO — Gov. Gavin Newsom's former chief of staff, Dana Williamson, left state service with two things: a federal corruption investigation and more than \$50,000 in pay for vacation time she accrued but never took.

State payroll records reviewed by The Times show Williamson used approximately \$30,000 in unused vacation time to remain on California's payroll through Jan. 31 — seven weeks after Newsom's office indicated

she had departed — before collecting an additional \$22,000 lump-sum payout for the hours she had left.

Large cash-outs for departing state workers with hundreds of hours of time off on the books have been a recurring issue in California. The state's unfunded liability for vacation and other leave owed to employees has ballooned in recent years to \$5.6 billion, fueled by generous time-off provisions and a long-standing failure to enforce policies that cap most employees' vacation balances at 640 hours.

Many state workers accu-

mulate large balances of unused vacation after decades of being on the government payroll. The typical public employee retires with more than two decades in public service, according to the California Public Employees' Retirement System. Their unused time off is paid when they leave state employment at their final rate of pay.

Williamson, however, amassed 462 hours of unused leave in less than two years on the job. She earned \$19,612 a month as the governor's chief of staff.

John Moorlach, director [See Williamson, A14]

Congress now an afterthought in war with Iran

GOP has blocked measures in both chambers that sought to limit the conflict.

By **ANA CEBALLOS**

WASHINGTON — Secretary of State Marco Rubio had some explaining to do when he arrived on Capitol Hill for a classified briefing with lawmakers in early March.

Members of Congress wanted to know why, two days earlier on Feb. 28, the United States and Israel had attacked Iran and killed its supreme leader — without notifying them first. After the briefing, Rubio told reporters that the U.S. preemptively struck Iran to get ahead of an Israeli attack. A day later, he tried to clarify his remarks.

"The bottom line is this: The president determined we were not going to get hit first," Rubio said. "It's that simple, guys."

For members of Congress, the moment underscored how marginal a role Congress has been able to play in a war that, two weeks in, has spread to more than a dozen neighboring countries, led to the deaths of at least 13 American service members and cost billions of dollars.

In the two weeks since the war began, Congress has largely been sidelined. Lawmakers have cycled through classified briefings, TV interviews and hallway scrums with reporters, but have taken little formal action related to Trump's war

U.S. plea to other nations unheeded

Leaders balk at Trump's call for warships; Iran says it's uninterested in peace talks. **WORLD, A4**

The 6 Americans who died in crash

A Kentucky mother and Alabama father among those on ill-fated refueling mission. **NATION, A6**

efforts — just two unsuccessful votes aimed at limiting the conflict.

Most of the debate has taken place online, where some Republican lawmakers have drawn rebukes from colleagues for saying America "needs more Islamophobia" and other Islamophobic rhetoric about Iran and its people.

At the same time, Trump has pressed Congress to focus instead on a controversial voting law, signaling to both GOP-led chambers that he wants their focus on the election rather than a historic moment abroad. The president, meanwhile, has offered shifting time frames for how long he intends to be at war in the Middle East, telling Fox News' Brian Kilmeade on Friday that he will conclude the hostilities when "I feel it in my bones."

Taking Trump's statements at face value, Democrats and some Republicans have begun to worry that more American troops could be deployed in Iran to complete the mission — and lawmakers are still trying to assess the war's threat to the

[See Congress, A5]



JULIANA YAMADA Los Angeles Times

THE PHILLIPS 66 refinery in Los Angeles will soon be closed. Valero, too, is shutting a plant in Benicia.

Rising energy prices snarl climate policy

Lawmakers, industry push back on plan to bolster state's cap-and-invest program.

By **HAYLEY SMITH**

As California regulators prepare for a massive update of the state's signature climate program, they face mounting pushback from lawmakers and oil industry groups who warn it could drive up already high energy costs.

Lawmakers voted last year to reauthorize the cap-and-invest program — formerly known as cap-and-trade — through 2045. The program progressively lowers the amount of greenhouse gas emissions allowed in the state and lets emitters buy and sell unused pollution credits, or allowances. It is key to California's climate strategy and generates billions in revenue for the state each year.

Although the program was always designed to ratchet down on emitters, some legislators who supported the extension say the draft unveiled by the California Air Resources Board could hit consumers and the energy sector hard at the wrong time.

Among the proposed updates, the plan would

tighten the cap on carbon dioxide emissions by 118 million tons by 2030. It would also adjust the state's system of free allowances, which have historically been given to oil refineries and other industrial facilities in the hope of keeping them in California. It would shift more of those free allowances from natural gas utilities to electric utilities.

A wave of public comments from lawmakers, oil companies, environmental advocates and consumers flooded the state Air Resources Board in advance of last week's deadline, and the agency will have until May to revise the plan and put it to a final vote.

Among the most notable critics are Democratic lawmakers who voted to extend the program last year. Some are concerned the plan would raise costs for refineries, driving more of them out of California and leaving the state more dependent on imported refined fuels. Others are worried the plan doesn't do enough to address high electricity costs.

In a letter to the state Air Resources Board, a coalition of 15 Democratic Assembly members, including Majority Leader Cecilia Aguiar-Curry (D-Winters), warned that the plan moves too fast for emitters to keep up, which they said will de-

[See Energy, A5]



ROBERT GAUTHIER Los Angeles Times

THE OSCARS

Amy Madigan won for supporting actress. Scan the code for Oscars coverage in our newspaper, and visit latimes.com/oscars2026.



Israeli troops kill 4 in family car

Parents, two children are slain in West Bank, rescuers say. Officials say vehicle sped toward forces. **WORLD, A2**

State's national parks set record

Despite executive orders, layoffs and other challenges, nearly 12 million visited last year. **CALIFORNIA, B1**

Lakers prevail in overtime thriller

Some late magic from Reaves and Dončić helps carry L.A. to big 127-125 home win against the Nuggets. **SPORTS, D6**

Weather

Mostly sunny. L.A. Basin: 92°/62. **B6**

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